

or a brochure, you should definitely go in for the HP. But if you want an economical MFD, nothing even comes close to the Lexmark X7170, which printed a whopping 22 pages in the 10 per cent ink usage test. The closest anyone got to it was the Brother MFC 3240C, which printed a decent 17 pages. The HP 2310 came fourth, with 15 pages, after the HP 1608, which printed 16. The Epson proved to be an ink-hungry beast, printing just two pages—and there wasn't any difference in terms of quality!



Brother MFC-210C

When buying an MFD or a printer for your home or office, always find out the cost of printing a single page. Naturally, lower is better. This applies especially to offices where the printing load is greater.

Scanning

Remember never to go by the marketing jargon of maximum dpi and interpolated dpi. These are software-enhanced resolutions and are not the real hardware capabilities of the device. Always insist on finding the real optical dpi of the scanner. The concept is similar to digital zoom and optical zoom on digital cameras. While you may have digital zoom in excess of 40x, it will never give you the clarity as that of a 24x optical zoom.

The first thing we tested was the warm-up time of the scanner. For this, we took a cold scanner and scanned an A4-size image five times over, and averaged the recorded times. The fastest device here was the Lexmark X7170 with nine seconds, followed closely by the HP 1608 at 11.1 seconds and the HP PSC 2310 with 14 seconds.

The Brother MFC 3240 failed this test, and we could not get preview values. The other sheet-fed scanner, the HP 4255, did let us do a preview job, although it was not pretty—it took 42 seconds!

This time, Epson took a break from bringing up the rear by finishing second-last; the rear was brought up by the HP 5510 at 16 seconds.

While testing for the resolutions with a resolution card, almost all scanners were able to scan 3/5 boxes at 600 dpi, except for the two Brothers and the HP OfficeJet 5510. They could manage only 2/5 boxes. The reason we did not expect any of the scanners to scan the remaining two boxes was that they were created at a much higher resolution of 1200-2400 dpi, and are not really needed for an office scanning environment—so we restricted our scanning tests to a resolution of 600 dpi.

We then got out the iT8 card to test the scanners' ability to distinguish different shades of colours. This test was given the highest weightage. Here, surprisingly, the HP 4255 and the HP 1608 outshone the rest by reading all 22 shades of black. They were closely followed by the Lexmark X7170, which detected 21 of the 22 shades.

The Brother MFC 3240C came a consistent third here. Here, the

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rear was brought up by HP 5510 and the other Brother device.

One thing is for sure: if you do a lot of scanning and are particular about accuracy, you should give the Epson Stylus CX1500 a look. Although it is ink-hungry when it comes to printing and is slow in terms of scanning, it does not compromise on clarity.

Copying

Now, by virtue of having a scanner and a printer in the same package, the device can also double up as a copier. To test the copying functionality of the MFDs we used the copier as a stand alone function without the device being connected to the PC. We tested the speed of copying (both black and colour) as well as the quality of the copies produced.

In terms of sheer speed, the Lexmark X7170 outpaced everyone else by copying the B&W document in 20 seconds and the colour document in 39 seconds. It was followed closely in B&W copying by the HP PSC 2310 at 22 seconds, although it did stutter in colour copying, giving a time of 54 seconds!



HP officejet 5510 all-in-one

The second-fastest in colour copying was the Brother MFD 210C at 41.9 seconds. It was also the best quality copier in this test, although the Lexmark X7170

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